



HOMEWORK 1: STRATEGY & S.W.O.T.

What is STRATEGY?

Strategy defines what you want to accomplish within a designated amount of time. It sets the direction and narrows the scope of your marketing resources so you can connect who you are (Values/Vision) with the people you want to reach (Target Audience).

Strategy:

1. Is developed through the lens of your church's "S.W.O.T."
 - **Strengths:** What do we do well? What are we known for?
 - **Weaknesses:** What do we not do well that we either need to change or stop doing? What negative perceptions do we need to change?
 - **Opportunities:** What are we doing that we should nurture? What should we start doing?
 - **Threats:** What in our environment or outside of our control prevents or could prevent us from being successful?
2. Defines your **Target Audience:** Who are the people you will focus your primary marketing toward?
3. Sets a **Strategic Objective** - something your church will do to connect with your Target Audience in a way that brings them into a new relationship with your church.
4. Paints a picture of what success looks like by clearly stating **Goals**.
5. Decides how you want to prioritize your church's **Resources** (financial, human, facilities) to accomplish your goals.

How does creating a Strategy impact your MARKETING PLAN?

A Strategy customizes your **MARKETING PLAN**. You draw conclusions and create a plan based on everything you know and have learned about your church, how it is perceived and the opportunities that lie ahead.

Example:

By taking the time to do intentional discovery through the Marketing Plan Process, a church learns that the percentage of young adults in the area is significantly higher than the percentage represented in their church. They have special programs and ministries directed toward young adults, but those are stagnant.

While conducting surveys, interviews and gatherings the church learns that there is a strong desire among young adults to serve and meet social services needs.

The church realizes that the programs they are designing for young adults are purely for social purposes. But they have all kinds of ministries in the church centered around social services needs.

So they develop a marketing strategy to connect young adults to the service opportunities they have in the church.

They set a goal for their church to have 50% more young adults (18 to 35 year olds) serving in some kind of ministry capacity within 12 months. They develop marketing tactics and messages to connect more of the young adults in the church to service opportunities. They create marketing tactics and messages that showcase their church as a place to serve and make a difference, and they direct those toward their target audience of young adults.

Review/Respond

Review:

Review the following components of your **MARKETING PLAN**:

- Values
- Vision Statement
- Key Messaging/Elevator Statement
- All of the summary reports that resulted from **Step 2: Perception & Needs**

Respond:

We want you to be well prepared to participate in the S.W.O.T. analysis that will determine your **MARKETING PLAN'S** Strategy. Take some time alone right now to review the information listed above, then think through each of the questions on the following pages. Note your conclusions/insights so you can refer to them during the session.

To help get you thinking in the right direction, here is an example of a S.W.O.T. analysis based off the example you just read.

Example:

As this church conducted their S.W.O.T. exercise, and considered their target audience (18 to 35 year old/young adults) they identified the following:

Strengths:

Church Location: They are located in an established neighborhood of post-war bungalow homes that is experiencing renewal. Many young couples have moved to the area to rehab and live in these homes. They are also located next door to a public elementary school and offer free tutoring to children in grades 5 and 6.

Annual 4th of July Celebration: The highlight of every summer is the Annual 4th of July Celebration. Food, games, a free concert and fireworks draw a large crowd. It is both a major fellowship event for church members and a fun, free social gathering for the people of the community.

Weaknesses:

Limited Options: Church leaders examine their current programs for young adults and realize that the only option is a fairly advanced Sunday morning Bible study class working through the Bible in a two year curriculum. This is not an "easy point of entry" for newer people to the church.

Frustrating Results: While the Annual 4th of July Celebration brings many visitors to the grounds, church leaders see very limited results from the effort in terms of any bump in attendance following the event. People come, but they don't connect or get involved with the church. Many question the expense and effort for this "big party."

Playground Equipment: While the grounds of the church are attractive and tidy, the church playground equipment is outdated and, in some cases, in disrepair. Several broken swings, a rusted slide and inadequate safety ground coverings create both an unsafe environment and give the impression that the church does not value children.

Opportunities:

"Senior Smarts" Tutoring Program: The church has a strong relationship with a nearby public elementary school where the church's senior's group offers tutoring for students in grades 5 and 6. They would like to expand into more grades and serve more children, but the number of interested senior adults has reached a plateau. During the discussion of this opportunity, church leaders consider expanding the program by intentionally renaming the program and expanding it to include young adults as tutors. This would provide a natural entry point for area young adults to get involved and would put young adults from the church in contact with the parents of the children in the program as well.

"The Carpenter's Sons" Handyman Ministry: over a dozen retired men from the congregation serve together, offering free handyman services for single mothers, the elderly and others in the need, primarily from within the congregation. It provides excellent fellowship opportunities and meets the needs of the people of the church. As church leaders look around in their neighborhood, they realize that many of the young couples moving to the neighborhood are tackling significant home remodeling projects. Church leaders consider expanding the handyman ministry to include free "do-it-yourself" clinics to teach aspiring remodelers skills like carpentry, plumbing, electrical, tile, roofing, etc.

Threats:

Children's sporting teams/activities are extremely popular and many families are involved in leagues that host games on both Saturday and Sunday mornings. This competes for the time and attention of both our own church members and area families.

Data shows that overall church attendance is in decline in the United States, and peoples impressions of Christianity and churches in general is not as favorable as it was even a few years ago.



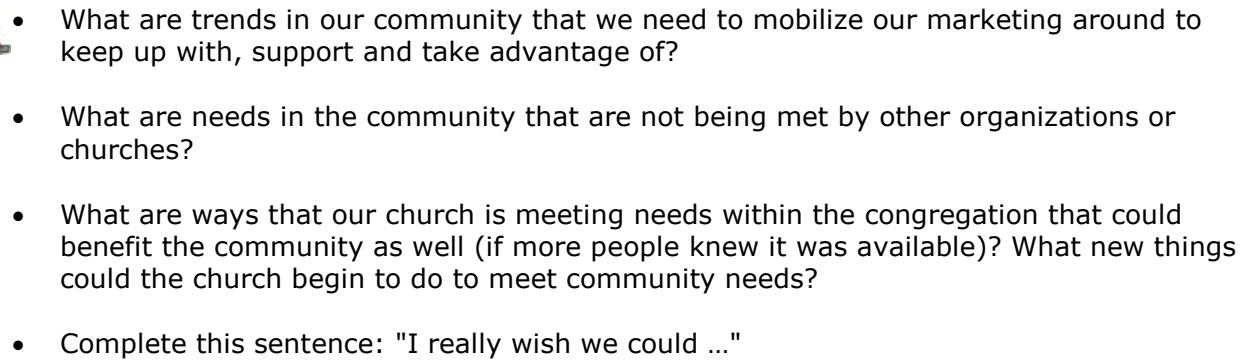
- What does our *congregation* say are our church's strengths? What are they talking positively about?
- What does our *community* say are our church's strengths? What are they talking positively about?
- What congregational and community perceptions align with our vision?
- What are needs in the community our church is meeting?
- What are some assets within your church? (e.g. the small, never-used building on the property)
- Complete this sentence: "We are great at ..."

Step 3: Strategy

- What does our **congregation** say are our church's weaknesses? What are they talking negatively about?
- What does our **community** say are our church's weaknesses? What are they talking negatively about?
- What congregational and community perceptions conflict with or compete with our vision?
- What are needs in the community that our church could be meeting but is not?
- What are some liabilities within your church? (e.g. the lack of handicap accessibility)
- Complete this sentence: "We are not good at ..."

[illegible]

Consider your answers to these questions about opportunities your church has to make an impact. Note your thoughts below.

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- What are some events that threaten (cause tension) with our church's event calendar and/or scheduling?
- What contributes to a declining membership?
- What are trends in our community that threaten our impact?
- What is the succession plan for our church leadership?
- What competes for attention and waters down our key messaging?
- Review the threats you listed above then complete this sentence, "I really wish we could, but ... "

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